

one sentence which settled into my young mind like a glorious light. My father never whipped me again, and I believe I gave him no reason to whip me. Yet I did live my own life, perhaps compromising here and there as a child must, yet always winning more and more freedom to *be myself* because my mind conceived so firmly that to be myself was what I wanted. Let me add that my stepmother's influence at length made a fine person out of my father. A child also can be so mercilessly preached at, endlessly corrected and admonished "for his own good" that soon no *self* respecting remains. The child becomes an adult who forever will lean upon others.

*Never interfere with anyone else's possession of himself.* Do not preach unless you are a professional preacher. Do not insistently and remorselessly teach unless you are a professional teacher; and even then, teaching should be limited to the teaching of definite skills and background knowledge.

Do not expect any other person to meet your definition of "perfect." Do not expect anything to appear perfect to you, and bear in mind that imperfections give variety to the world. In saying this I am reminded of a man who said that if there is a Heaven, he did not wish to go to Heaven when he died. Interested, I asked him to explain.

"Well," he said, "I don't see any enjoyment in living where everything is perfect."

I do not think it is an accident that this man is one of the best-known businessmen in America, and that he owns a large measure of peace of mind. Also, I have never heard of his trying to reform anybody. He says, as I too wish to say, that it is perfectly possible to get along with people as they are, with their faults—and with all their virtues.

One good way to maintain possession of your own mind and to allow others to possess their own minds is to keep certain views to yourself. You are not required to go through life explaining yourself, and often it is a mistake to do so. This applies particularly to controversial subjects such as religion and politics. Exposing your views in these matters is almost bound to cause unnecessary conflict.

No one knows how I stand on either religion or politics. No one, therefore, can get me riled or rile themselves in regard to my standpoint.

Many busybodies have tried to pry into my mind to see what they will discover in those areas. Once a woman wrote to me: "How come I see no mention of Jesus in any of your writings?"